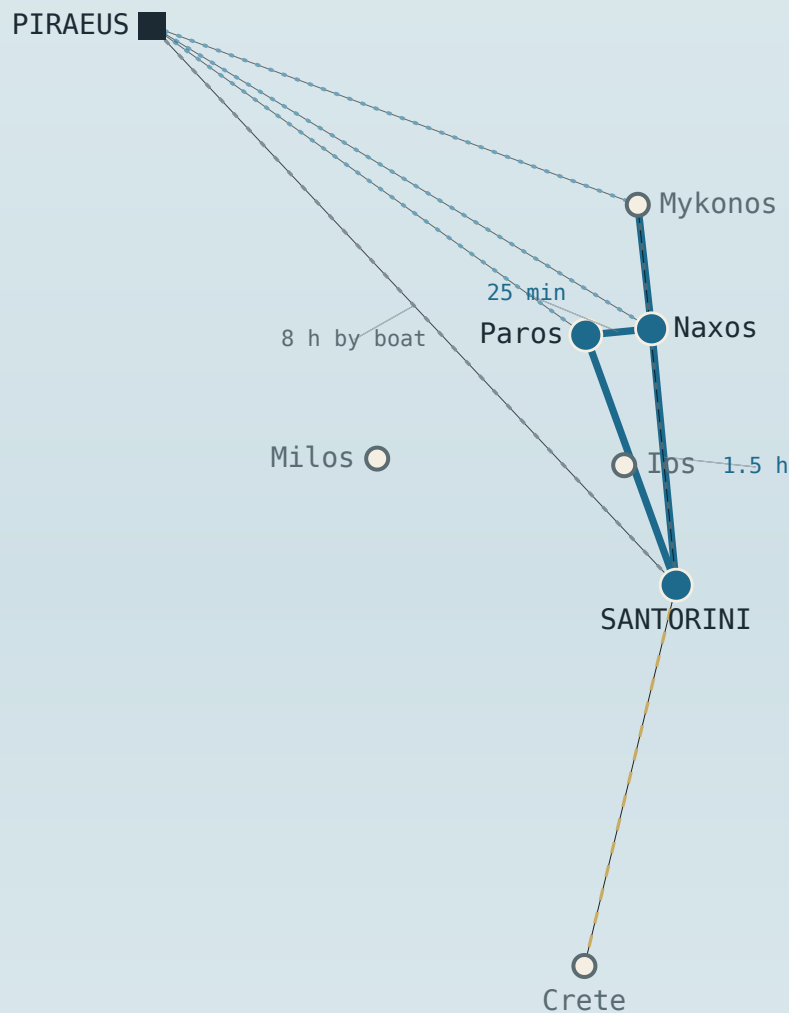


THE GREECE DOSSIER

Greece, in Order.



*Every island change costs the better part of a day.
A great trip is decided by order, not by scenery.*

A DECISION MANUAL FOR THE FIRST-TIME AMERICAN VISITOR

greeceforamericans.com · first edition

A trip decided by order.

This is not a list of the prettiest islands. It is the set of decisions your trip really turns on — argued, with the arithmetic shown, so you can disagree with us and still come out ahead.

Most Greece guides answer the question ‘which island is most beautiful?’ It is the wrong question, and answering it is how a first trip goes wrong. The islands are beautiful in the way the photographs promise; almost none of them will disappoint you once you are standing on them. What disappoints is the shape of the trip — too many islands, in the wrong order, in the wrong month, reached by a boat that didn’t run.

So this book answers a different question: not where to go, but how to decide. Each of the chapters that follow resolves one choice a first-time visitor is already agonising over — how many islands, in what order, by which boat, in which season — and resolves it with visible reasoning and a verdict you are free to reject. Where a fact is structural, we say so. Where a number moves, we send you to the dated annex rather than print a figure that will be wrong by spring.

The premise is that you are an intelligent adult spending real money on a rare trip, and that you would rather be shown the trade than handed a conclusion. Read the arithmetic. Disagree where you like. This trip is not our imagined trip. The book is built to survive that — a good decision manual makes you a better decider, not an obedient one.

Two documents, four marks.

This book is built to age well. That means separating what stays true for years from what will be wrong by spring — and telling you, on every claim, which it is.

- **STRUCTURAL** — Geography and arithmetic that don’t change — distances, the pacing law, the caldera’s shape.
- **STABLE** — An ordering or judgement that holds, even if a figure attached to it moves.
- ◊ **OFFICIAL** — A published rule or requirement — entry, the 90/180 limit, the driving permit.
- ◆ **VOLATILE** — A price, a schedule, a release window. These live on the Field Sheet, never in the book.

The Book is what you read before the trip: the decisions, the reasoning, the shape. It carries no live prices, because a printed price is a lie with a long shelf life. The Field Sheet is the dated annex — the volatile figures, verified at press time or pointed to an official source, and reissued as they move. When the two disagree, the Sheet wins.

Using this on the trip: read the decisions before you book, carry the wallet card at the back, and open the Field Sheet in your travel week to confirm the moving parts — the sailings, the entry status, the rates.

The Greece Dossier

OPENING

The contract	
How to read this	

THE GROUND

Greece is a sequence, not a place	
Why last year's timetable lies to you	

BEFORE THE TRIP

The pre-departure list, by deadline	
-------------------------------------	-------

THE DECISIONS

01 How many islands can you fit?		02 Which islands, and in what order?	
03 Fast boat or slow?		04 When should you go?	
05 Is Santorini worth it — how long?		06 Santorini or Mykonos — or both?	
07 Naxos or Paros for the second island?		08 How many days does Athens earn?	
09 Cards or cash — the costly prompt?		10 Nonstop or connection?	
11 What do you need to get in?		12 How not to eat badly?	

PLANNING

Where to sleep — six bases	
Ten days, as operations	
Twenty failure modes, by consequence	

THE ANNEXES

The wallet card	
What this won't tell you	
The Field Sheet	

Greece is a sequence, not a place.

One fact reorganises the entire trip: every island change costs the better part of a day, and the boat that makes it runs on the season's terms, not yours.

Here is the thing that catches first-timers off guard: you don't drive Greece, you ferry it. The islands are the destination and the boats between them are how the trip strings together. Nearly everything radiates from one point — Piraeus, Athens's port, a short Metro ride from the centre — and from there the ferries fan out across the Aegean. Once that clicks, Greece stops feeling overwhelming and starts feeling like a route you assemble.

The route has a cost the map hides. Every island change is far more than the crossing; you pack, check out, cross to the port, wait, sail, land, find the next room, and settle. Realistically each hop eats most of a day. Three islands in a week is not seven beach days; it is four or five, the rest spent in transit. That single piece of arithmetic decides more about a Greek trip than any sight. • STRUCTURAL

FIG. 01

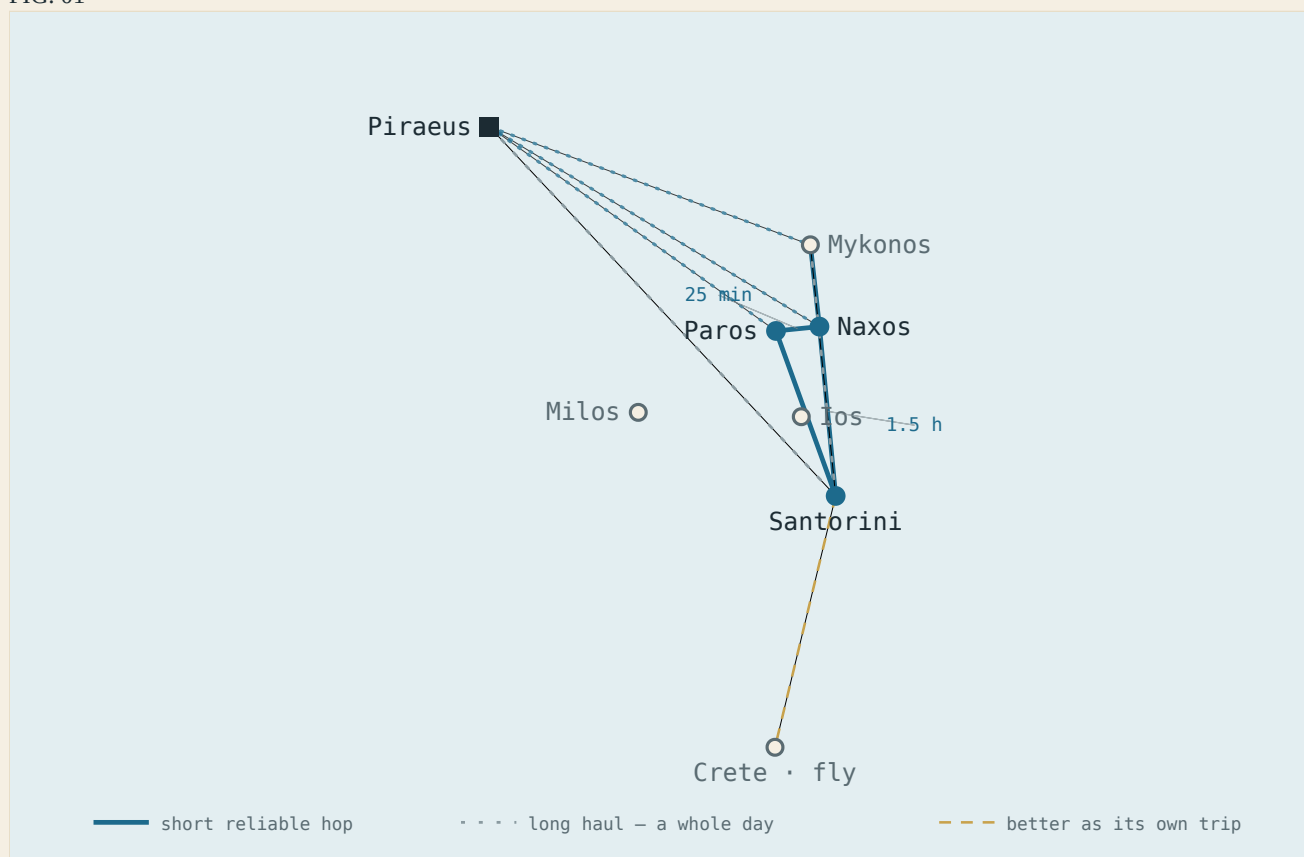


FIG. 01 · THE CYCLADES FROM PIRAEUS — SHORT HOPS INSIDE THE GROUP, LONG HAULS TO THE CORNERS

It compounds with two forces the traveller doesn't control. The first is distance: islands in one group sit close, with short reliable hops; jump to a distant group and you buy long crossings and backtracks through Athens. The second is season: schedules thin as summer fades, the fast boats cancel in high wind, and less-busy routes are confirmed only close to the date. The trip you can take is the intersection of where you want to go and what is sailing when you go. ♦ VOLATILE

Everything in this book descends from that. The count comes first because the hops are expensive. The order comes next because distance is fixed. The season sits near the top because it decides what runs at all. Get those three right and the islands take care of themselves; get them wrong and no island, however beautiful, can rescue the week.

There is a particular moment on the deck of a slow ferry, an hour out of Piraeus, when the mainland has dropped below the horizon and the first island has not yet risen, and the whole Aegean is just wind and light and a paper cup of coffee going cold in your hand. Nobody schedules that moment. It is what the slow boat is for.

Why last year's timetable lies to you.

The obvious move — look up the ferry schedule and build the trip around it — fails in a way that costs first-timers days.

The instinct is to find a timetable and plan against it. The problem is that Greek ferry schedules are seasonal and confirmed closer to the travel date, especially on less-busy routes — so the schedule you find in January is a description of last year, not a promise about yours. Build a tight, multi-hop itinerary on it and a single quietly-dropped sailing takes the entire chain down.

This is why the book leans on structure over specifics. The distances between islands don't change; the pacing law doesn't change; the fact that the fast boat cancels first in high wind doesn't change. Those you can plan around a year out. The specific 8:05 to Santorini on the second Tuesday of October is not knowable that far ahead and not worth pretending to know. Plan the shape now; confirm the sailings in your travel week. ● STABLE

The pre-departure list, by deadline.

Everything here has a date attached. The passport and the driving permit cannot be fixed once you have left; do these first.

THE CHECKLIST	DEADLINE · ACTION
3–6 months out	Check your passport: valid at least three months beyond your Schengen departure, issued within the previous ten years. Renew now if either fails. ♦ OFFICIAL
3–6 months out	Book flights — nonstop to Athens if your dates allow. Nonstops cluster spring through fall and sell out for peak. ♦ VOLATILE
2–3 months out	If you'll drive on a bigger island, get an International Driving Permit from AAA before you leave — you cannot get a valid one in Greece, and without it a rental desk can refuse the car and your insurance may be void. ● STRUCTURAL
2–3 months out	Reserve rooms, especially on Santorini and Mykonos in peak; the iconic caldera and two-icon pairings book out first. ♦ VOLATILE
1–2 months out	Get a no-foreign-transaction-fee card if you don't have one; carry Visa or Mastercard, not Amex alone. ● STRUCTURAL
2–4 weeks out	Buy an eSIM to install before you land — cheaper than carrier roaming and working the moment you arrive. ● STABLE
Your travel week	Confirm the specific ferry sailings for your dates — they're set close to travel, especially on quieter routes. Re-check the ETIAS status officially. ♦ VOLATILE
Your travel week	Pack light: a carry-on or modest wheeled case beats an overstuffed bag on port hikes, island steps, and cobbles. ● STRUCTURAL

How many islands can you actually fit?

Almost every disappointing first trip to Greece starts as an ambitious one. The traveller sketches five islands onto a ten-day map, because five islands is what the photographs promise, and arrives home having seen mostly ferry terminals. The mistake is arithmetic, not taste: an island change is never just the crossing. You pack, check out, cross the island to the port, wait, sail, land, find the next room, and settle — and that is most of a day, gone, before you have swum anywhere.

FIG. 01

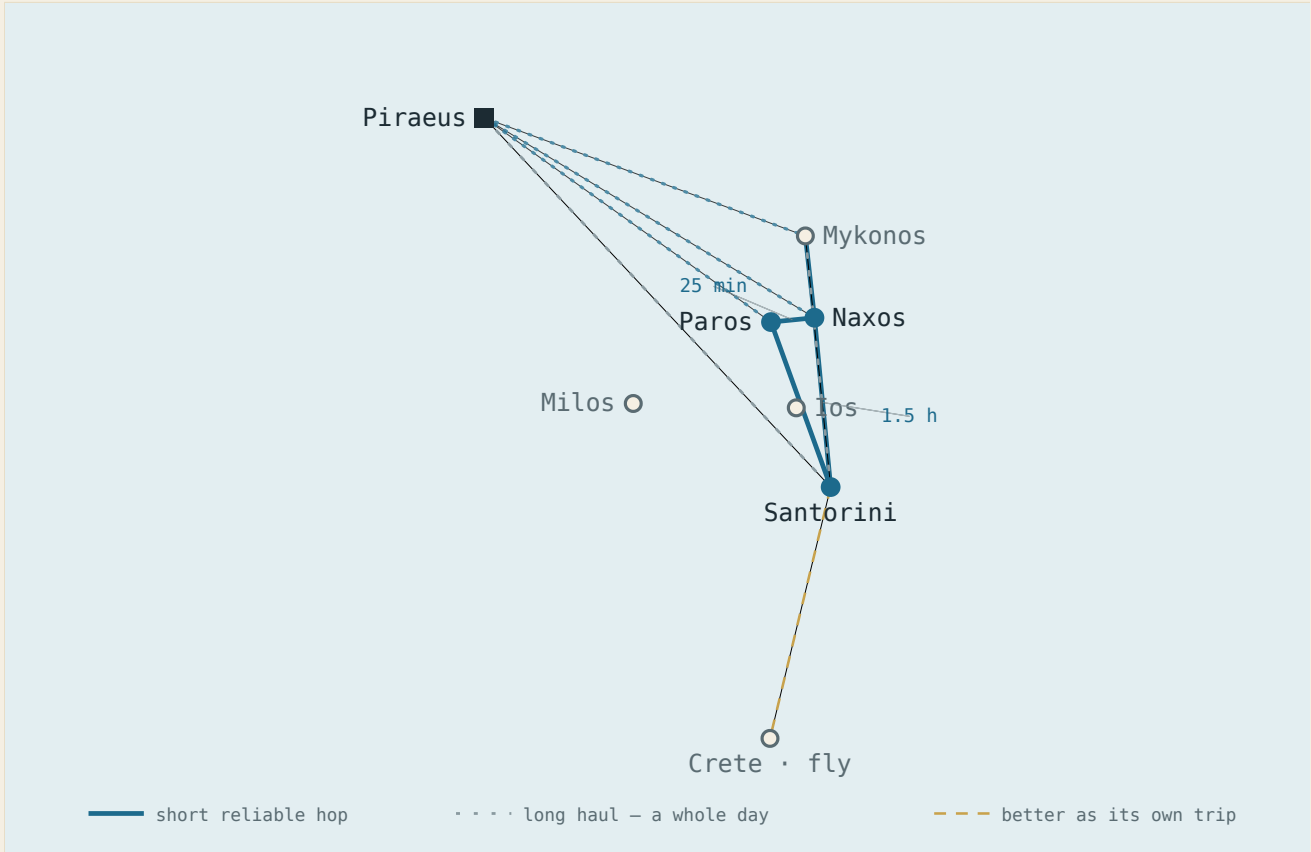


FIG. 01 • THE CYCLADES FROM PIRAEUS — SHORT HOPS INSIDE THE GROUP, LONG HAULS TO THE CORNERS

WHAT EACH TRIP LENGTH REALLY HOLDS • FIRST-TIME VISITOR, RELAXED PACE

THE LEDGER

ISLANDS • WHAT IT BUYS

5 days — one island, plus Athens ● STRUCTURAL	0–1 hop
7 days — two islands, plus Athens ● STRUCTURAL	2 hops
10 days — two to three islands ● STRUCTURAL	2–3 hops
14 days — three to four islands, or fold in Crete ● STRUCTURAL	3 hops + a flight

Book one island per three nights, and stop one island short of what the map seems to allow. Three islands in ten days is not seven beach days; it is four or five, with the rest spent in transit. The travellers who come home raving are almost never the ones who ‘did’ six islands. Depth beats breadth here more than almost anywhere: two islands you come to know beat five you photographed and left.

IF YES

you value swimming and long lunches over a checklist — then fewer is the entire point

IF NO

you genuinely prefer motion to rest, and treat the ferry deck as part of the trip — then add one, never two

The pacing law is structural and will not change. The one number that moves is the ferry timetable that enforces it ♦ VOLATILE → Field Sheet — the count is safe; the specific sailings are not.

DECISION 02 · THE ROUTE

Which islands, and in what order?

Once the count is settled, the order is the trip. Combine the wrong pair and you will spend the vacation on long sailings and connections that do not exist; combine the right ones and the islands flow into each other. The single rule underneath every good route is this: stay inside one island group. Islands in the same group sit close together with frequent, reliable crossings. Jump between distant groups — the Cyclades to the Ionian, say — and you buy long crossings, sparse connections, and a backtrack through Athens.

THE PAIRINGS, SCORED ON HOW THEY SAIL

THE LEDGER

PAIRING · THE TRADE

Santorini + Naxos (or Paros) — icon with a relaxed, better-value island ● STRUCTURAL	the classic
Mykonos + Santorini — the two icons, glossiest and priciest ● STRUCTURAL	book early
Paros + Naxos — two authentic islands a short hop apart ● STRUCTURAL	best value
Santorini + Crete — a long crossing; both deserve real time ● STABLE	avoid, first trip
Cyclades + a distant group in one short trip ● STABLE	avoid

Run Naxos → Santorini, and end on Santorini. Pair one relaxed, authentic island with the showstopper, keep the ferry legs short by moving between neighbours, and finish on Santorini so the quick flight home replaces a long ferry day. Santorini works as a finale, not a midpoint. Want energy over quiet villages? Swap Naxos for Mykonos and the logic holds.

IF YES

you want the postcard and a real Greek island both — then the classic pair is right

IF NO

you have two weeks and want variety — then add Paros in the middle, or Crete by flight, never by the long boat

Which islands are close is a fact of geography and does not change ● STRUCTURAL. Which specific sailings connect them on your dates does ♦ VOLATILE → Field Sheet.

DECISION 03 · THE FERRY

Fast boat or slow — and does it matter?

The same route is usually served by two kinds of boat, and first-timers treat the choice as trivial. It is not. Conventional ferries are the big, stable workhorses — cheaper, steadier, with open decks and room to walk. High-speed catamarans cut the time roughly in half, cost noticeably more, seat you airline-style with little deck access, and — the part that matters — get cancelled far more often when the wind is up.

FIG. 02

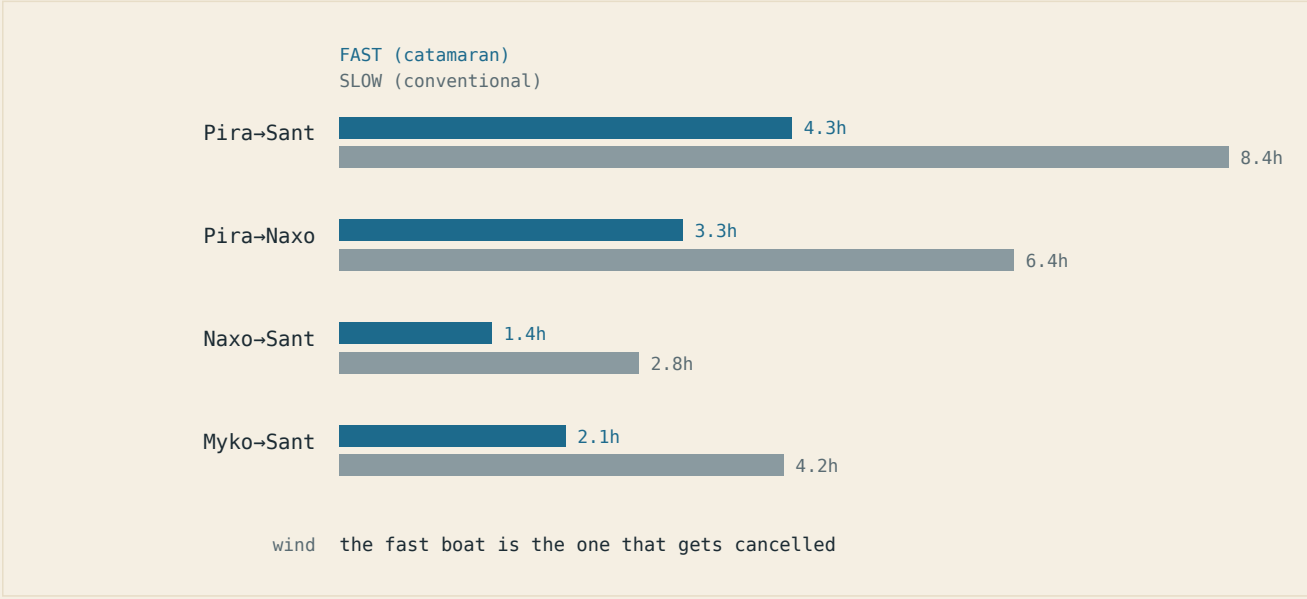


FIG. 02 · FAST VERSUS SLOW — TIME SAVED SHRINKS ON SHORT LEGS; WIND CANCELS THE FAST BOAT FIRST

THE TRADE, PER LEG · CROSSING HOURS COMPUTED FROM REAL DISTANCES

THE LEDGER	LEG · FAST / SLOW
Piraeus → Santorini — the long haul ● STRUCTURAL	~5 h / ~8 h
Naxos → Santorini — a short hop ● STRUCTURAL	~1.4 h / ~2.8 h
Mykonos → Santorini ● STRUCTURAL	~2 h / ~4 h
On any leg, in high wind ● STRUCTURAL	fast cancels first

Take the fast boat on the long legs; the slow boat is fine, often nicer, on the short ones. On a multi-hour haul the time saved earns the premium. On a ninety-minute hop the difference is small and the conventional boat is the easy, cheap, steadier choice — and in a stiff meltemi it is also the one still sailing. Deck or economy class is all you need for a Cycladic hop; the cabins rarely repay their cost on a short crossing.

IF YES	IF NO
your schedule is tight or you're prone to seasickness on a long leg — pay for fast	the sea is up, or the leg is short — the slow boat is the resilient call

Fares, exact durations, and whether a given sailing runs on your date all move by season ♦ VOLATILE → Field Sheet. Book high-speed and any July–August sailing well ahead; they sell out.

DECISION 04 · THE SEASON

When should you go?

Season is not the eighth decision in Greece; it is close to the first, because it decides crowds, price, heat, and even which island businesses are open. The country has a long warm season with a distinct rhythm, and the sweet spot is not summer. Late spring and early fall — the windows bracketing the July–August peak — hit several good things at once: warm and swimmable, far thinner crowds, and prices off their highs, with everything still running.

FIG. 03

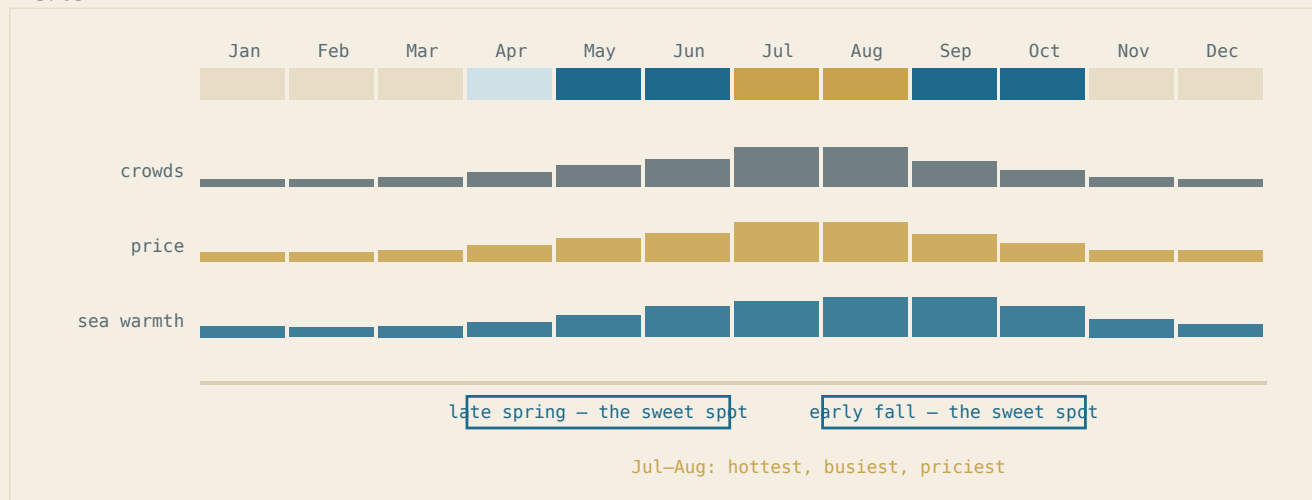


FIG. 03 · THE YEAR, IN CROWDS, PRICE, AND SEA WARMTH — THE SWEET SPOTS BRACKET THE PEAK

THE WINDOWS, ON WHAT THEY COST AND WHAT THEY BUY

THE LEDGER

WINDOW · WHAT YOU GET

May–June — fresh, green, swimmable by June, modest crowds ● STRUCTURAL	sweet spot
July–August — hottest, busiest, priciest, fullest scene ● STRUCTURAL	peak
September–early October — warmest sea, crowds gone ● STRUCTURAL	sweet spot
Winter — quiet, cheap, many island businesses shut ● STRUCTURAL	Athens only

Go in late September if you can, late May if you can't. September is many travellers' single favourite month: the sea is at its warmest after the summer, the weather still holds, and the peak crowds have gone. Late spring gives you wildflowers and green hills instead of warm sea. Both beat the peak on every axis except sheer scene. Winter is for Athens and culture, not the islands.

IF YES

you want the best balance of weather, value, and space — take the shoulder

IF NO

you specifically want the full, loud summer scene and will pay for it — take July

The season rhythm is structural ● STRUCTURAL. Exactly which businesses are open in the shoulder edges, and this year's prices, belong on the Sheet ♦ VOLATILE → Field Sheet.

DECISION 05 · SANTORINI

Is Santorini worth it — and for how long?

Santorini is the island on the postcard and the most misunderstood in Greece. The first thing to understand is not a sight but a geometry: the island is the rim of a flooded volcanic caldera. The famous towns — Oia, Imerovigli, Fira — perch on the caldera's western edge, which is where the views and the sunsets are. The beaches, black and red volcanic sand, are on the opposite eastern side, away from the cliffs. Miss that and you book the wrong side of the island for what you came to do.

FIG. 04

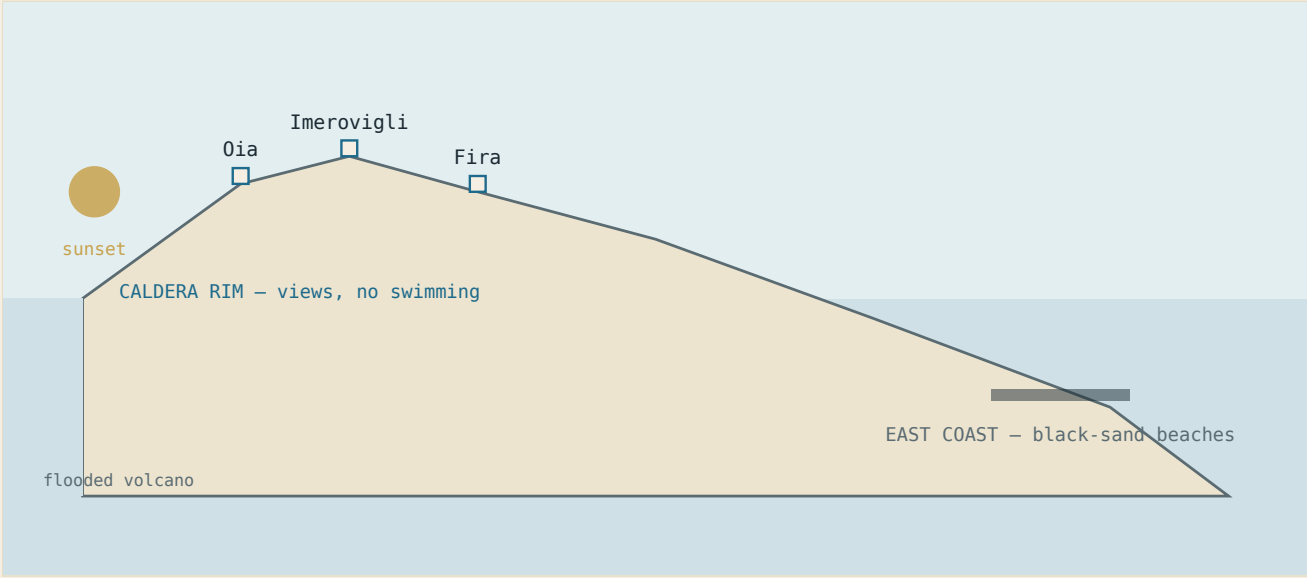


FIG. 04 · SANTORINI IN SECTION — THE CALDERA RIM IS FOR VIEWS, THE EAST COAST IS FOR SWIMMING

THE ISLAND, READ AS TWO COASTS

THE LEDGER

SIDE · WHAT IT'S FOR

Caldera rim — Oia, Imerovigli, Fira: the views, the sunset ● STRUCTURAL	look, don't swim
East coast — black-sand beaches, calmer water ● STRUCTURAL	swim here
Oia at sunset — spectacular, and the island's worst crowd ● STRUCTURAL	arrive early or elsewhere
Two to three days ● STRUCTURAL	enough for a first-timer

Yes — for two or three days, as the finale, with your bed on the caldera and your swimming on the east coast. The sunset lives up to the hype and draws the island's densest crowd; the answer is not to skip it but to watch it from Imerovigli or Fira, or to reach Oia well before the crush. Longer than three days and the caldera towns start to feel like a stage set at capacity.

IF YES	IF NO
this is a once-in-a-decade trip and the caldera is the reason — give it the finale	you came to swim and relax above all — give it two nights and more to Naxos

The caldera geography is permanent ● STRUCTURAL. If you arrive by cruise, the port works differently — ships anchor and tender to the Old Port below Fira, then it's the cable car, the 600 steps, or the donkeys up the cliff. Cable-car waits are the volatile part ♦ VOLATILE → Field Sheet.

DECISION 06 · THE ICONS

Santorini or Mykonos — or both?

The two famous islands are famous for opposite reasons, and travellers who book both without noticing that end up half-satisfied twice. Santorini is scenery and ceremony — the caldera, the sunset, the honeymoon photograph. Mykonos is energy — beach clubs, nightlife, a see-and-be-seen glamour. Both are beautiful; neither is a substitute for the other, and the pairing is the glossiest and priciest a first trip can make.

Santorini — caldera, sunset, ceremony ● STRUCTURAL	couples, once-in-a-decade
Mykonos — nightlife, beach clubs, glamour ● STRUCTURAL	energy, going out
Both, back to back — the two-icon week ● STRUCTURAL	priciest; book early
Neither — Naxos and Paros instead ● STRUCTURAL	value, authenticity

Pick the one that matches how you want the evenings to feel, and spend the second island's nights on a quieter one. If the trip is romantic or scenic, Santorini is the icon to keep and Naxos the second island. If it is social and loud, keep Mykonos and let Santorini be a two-night finale. Booking both is a valid, expensive choice — just make it on purpose, not by default, and reserve early.

IF YES

you want maximum contrast and the budget is there — the two-icon pairing works

IF NO

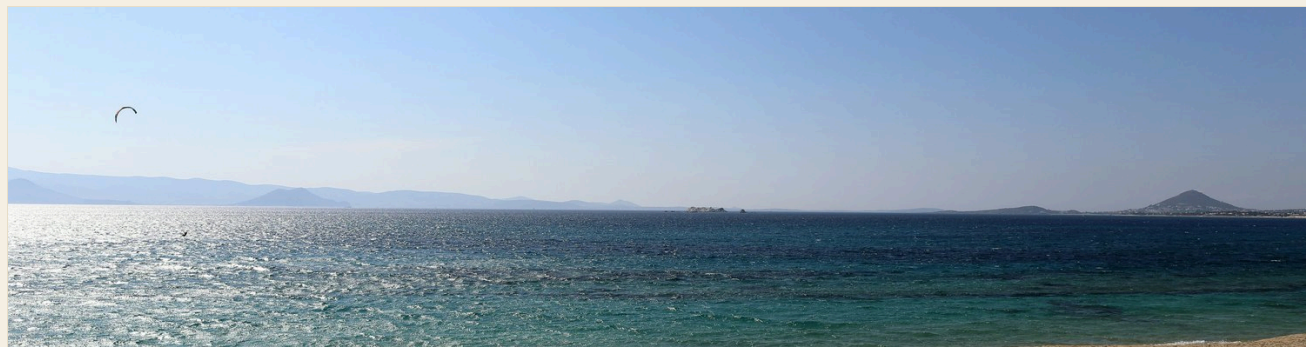
you'd rather one icon and one real village — the better first-trip shape

Which island suits which temperament is stable ● STABLE. Peak-season room and club prices are steep and move — they live on the Sheet ♦ VOLATILE → Field Sheet.

DECISION 07 · THE VALUE

Naxos or Paros for the second island?

The best-value decision on the whole trip is which of the two sane, beautiful, well-priced Cyclades you give your second island to. Naxos and Paros sit a short hop apart — twenty-odd minutes by fast boat — and both offer real villages, excellent food, long beaches, and relaxed evenings without the famous-island price tags. You cannot go wrong; you can only optimise.



PL. A · A NAXOS BEACH OUT OF SEASON — THE VALUE ISLANDS TRADE FAME FOR SPACE

THE VALUE PAIR, ON THEIR SMALL REAL DIFFERENCES

THE LEDGER

ISLAND · ITS EDGE

Naxos — largest Cyclade: long sandy beaches, mountain villages, the Portara ● STRUCTURAL	space, variety
Paros — the natural hub: connects to Naxos, Mykonos, Santorini ● STRUCTURAL	connections
Both — a two-island Cyclades leg on their own ● STRUCTURAL	the value week

Naxos if you want one island to hold you for three nights; Paros if you're hopping and want the easiest connections. Naxos is bigger and more self-sufficient — sand, hill villages, and enough to fill several days without a boat. Paros is the better hub, a short hop from Naxos and well-linked onward to Santorini and Mykonos, which makes it the smarter base for a three-island run.

IF YES

you're settling into one relaxed island — Naxos has more to hold you

IF NO

you're stringing three islands together — Paros connects them best

DECISION 08 · ATHENS

How many days does Athens earn?

Most first trips to Greece begin in Athens whether the traveller plans it or not: it is where the transatlantic flights land and where the ferries to the islands depart. The question is not whether to stop but how long, and the honest answer surprises people — two or three days, no more, for most first-timers. Athens is a superb on-ramp: the Acropolis, 2,500 years of history, and some of the country's best food, all in a compact, walkable core. It is an opener, not usually the main event.

FIG. 06

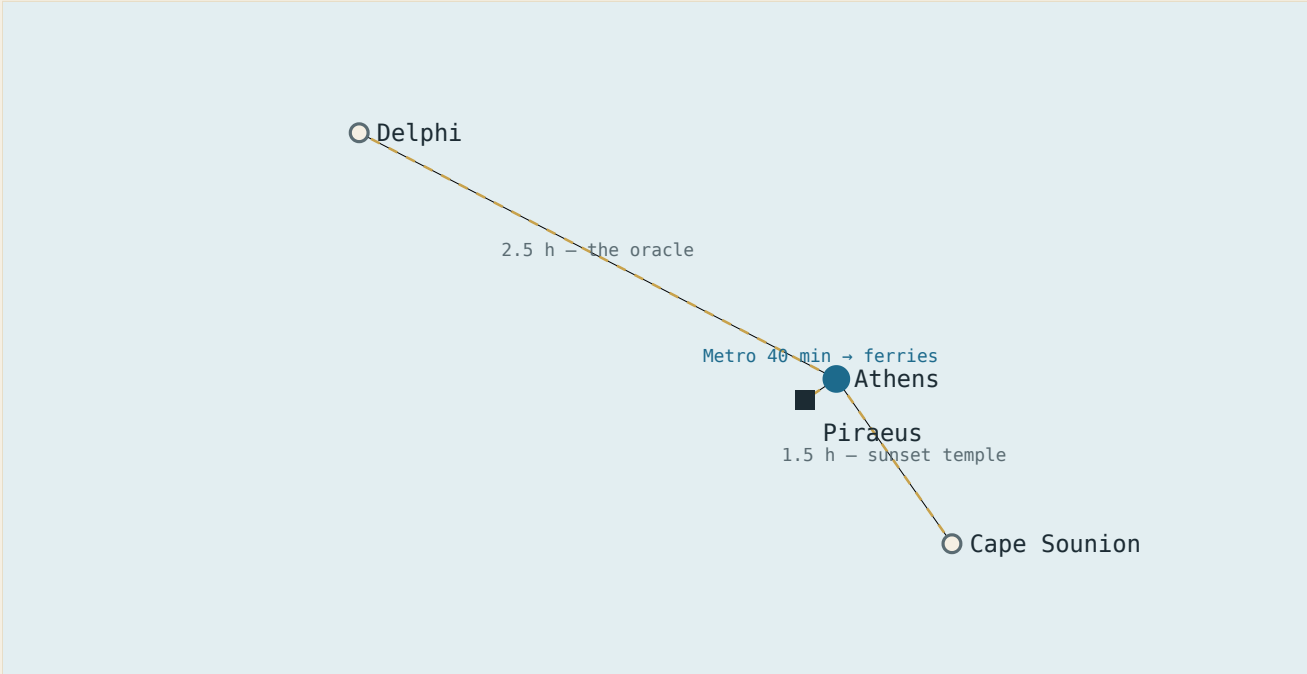


FIG. 06 · ATHENS AS A HUB — THE METRO TO THE FERRIES, AND THE TWO DAY-TRIP SPOKES

ATHENS BY THE DAY · BASED IN PLAKA, UNDER THE ACROPOLIS

THE LEDGER

DAYS · WHAT THEY BUY

Day one — ease in jet-lagged: Plaka's lanes, a first taverna ● STRUCTURAL	recovery
Day two — the Acropolis at opening, the museum, the Agora ● STRUCTURAL	the headliners
Day three — slow down, or a day trip: Sounion or Delphi ● STRUCTURAL	depth or a spoke
Beyond three — most travellers itch for the islands ● STRUCTURAL	move on

Two days on a tight week, three if you can spare it — and base in Plaka. Two days covers the essentials without a march; the old-town lanes under the Acropolis put you minutes from everything a first-timer wants. A third day earns either a slower pace or one day trip — Cape Sounion's sunset temple or Delphi's oracle. Give Athens four and you're borrowing an island day for a city that doesn't need it.

IF YES
you love ancient history and big-city food — the third day repays itself

IF NO
the beach is the whole point — two days, then Piraeus

Athens's role as the gateway and its walkable core are structural ● STRUCTURAL. Opening hours and any transit strike on your dates are the volatile part ♦ VOLATILE → Field Sheet.

Cards or cash — and the one prompt that costs you money?

Greece is card-friendly and easy once you know the ropes, and it has two specific traps that quietly cost Americans money on every trip. The first is a machine: the bright, standalone Euronet ATMs clustered in every tourist area, notorious for poor rates and high fees. The second is a question — the one the terminal asks when you pay — and the wrong answer is the single most expensive reflex an American brings to Greece.

WHERE THE MONEY LEAKS, AND THE HABIT THAT STOPS IT

THE LEDGER

HABIT • WHY

At the card reader — ‘charge in euros or dollars?’ • STRUCTURAL	always choose euros
At the ATM — Euronet vs a real Greek bank machine • STRUCTURAL	use a bank ATM
The card in your wallet — foreign-transaction fee or not • STRUCTURAL	bring a no-FX-fee card
Amex as your only card • STRUCTURAL	carry Visa / Mastercard too

Always choose euros, never dollars — and withdraw from bank ATMs, not Euronet. Choosing dollars triggers dynamic currency conversion, where the terminal applies its own bad rate plus a markup; paying in euros lets your own bank do the conversion at a fairer rate. Skip the standalone Euronet machines for ATMs attached to actual Greek banks. Bring a card that waives foreign-transaction fees, and don't rely on Amex alone.

IF YES

you carry a no-FX-fee card and answer ‘euros’ every time — you're set

IF NO

there is no against — this one is a rule, not a preference

The DCC and Euronet traps are structural and won't change • STRUCTURAL. Exchange rates move daily; don't memorise a fixed conversion — glance at the rate before you go

♦ VOLATILE → Field Sheet.

DECISION 10 • ARRIVAL

Nonstop or connection — does the flight decide day one?

Nearly every trip to Greece begins at Athens International, and how you get there shapes the first day more than travellers expect. A growing number of nonstops connect major U.S. cities to Athens in spring through fall; most land in the morning after an overnight crossing of roughly nine to eleven hours. A connection through a European hub costs you those morning hours and adds a place for bags to go missing before the islands.



PL. B • ARRIVAL BY SEA — THE FERRY THAT TURNS A LONG FLIGHT INTO THE FIRST ISLAND

Nonstop — overnight, lands ATH mid-morning ● STRUCTURAL	a usable first day
One-stop via a European hub ● STRUCTURAL	a lost afternoon
ATH → central Athens — Metro Line 3, ~40 min ● STRUCTURAL	a few euros
ATH → Piraeus for a same-day ferry ● STRUCTURAL	possible, not restful

Take the nonstop if it exists on your dates, and don't island-hop on arrival day. The nonstop lands you in Athens with a morning intact; a connection eats it. Either way, plan the first day as recovery, not performance — Metro into Plaka, a wander, a first taverna dinner, an early night. Sprinting to Piraeus for a same-day ferry is possible and rarely worth it on jet lag.

IF YES

a nonstop fits your dates — it buys a real first day; take it

IF NO

only a connection is available or affordable — then plan day one as a write-off

Which cities have nonstops shifts by season and year ♦ VOLATILE → Field Sheet. The Metro line and rough airport-to-centre time are stable ● STRUCTURAL.

DECISION 11 · ENTRY

What do you actually need to get in?

For a normal vacation, the entry requirements are refreshingly simple — and one detail trips up more Americans than all the others combined. No visa is needed for tourism: U.S. citizens get visa-free entry to Greece and the wider Schengen Area for short stays. What people get wrong is the passport rule and the clock: the 90/180 limit, and a passport that must be valid well beyond the trip and issued recently enough.

THE ENTRY CHECKLIST, IN ORDER OF WHAT GETS MISSED

THE LEDGER

ITEM · THE RULE

Passport — valid 3+ months beyond departure, issued within 10 years ◇ OFFICIAL	the usual trip-up
Visa — none for tourism, up to 90 days in any 180 ◇ OFFICIAL	no action
Proof of onward travel / funds, if asked ◇ OFFICIAL	have it ready
EES biometric border — already in effect; ETIAS on the horizon ◇ OFFICIAL	confirm officially

Check your passport's issue date and expiry today, and confirm the ETIAS status close to your trip. The passport rule — valid at least three months past your Schengen departure and issued within the previous ten years — catches more travellers than anything else, and it's fixable only before you fly. A new EU biometric border system is already running, and an online authorisation is coming; because these rules are changing, verify the current state with official sources in your travel week.

IF YES

your passport clears both tests and you'll re-check ETIAS — you're done

IF NO

there is no against — these are rules, and the passport one has a deadline

Whether ETIAS is live on your dates, and its fee, is the moving part ♦ VOLATILE → Field Sheet. The 90/180 rule and passport-validity requirement are official and stable ◇ OFFICIAL.

DECISION 12 · EATING

How do you not eat badly in a country this

good at food?

Greece makes it genuinely hard to eat badly and genuinely easy to eat touristically, and the difference is a handful of habits, not a list of restaurants. The taverna — casual, family-run, home-style — is where you want to be, distinct from the more formal estiatorio and the small-plates ouzeri and mezedopolio. The rules that separate a good meal from a great one are unwritten, and they outlive any list of names a guidebook could print.



PL. C · A TAVERNA TABLE, SET TO SHARE — THE RULE OUTLIVES ANY LIST OF NAMES

THE TAVERNA, DECODED

THE LEDGER

RULE · WHY IT WORKS

When — Greeks eat late; dinner from 9pm ● STRUCTURAL	arrive at 7 and you dine alone
Where — taverna, not estiatorio, for everyday food ● STRUCTURAL	the authentic default
How — order to share; small plates in waves ● STRUCTURAL	the point of the meal
The check — it won't come until you ask ● STRUCTURAL	not rudeness; rhythm

Eat late, order to share, and ask for the check — then let the meal take its time. Turn up at 9pm, pick a taverna over the formal room, order several plates for the table rather than a course each, and don't wait for a bill that isn't coming until you signal for it. The unhurried, convivial rhythm is not a delay to be managed; it is the meal. Follow the locals' clock and the food follows.

IF YES
you're happy to eat late and share — you'll eat brilliantly for little

IF NO
you need an early, individual-plate dinner — you can, but you'll miss the point

The taverna's rhythm and the late clock are cultural constants ● STRUCTURAL. Specific rooms go in and out of favour by the season, which is exactly why this book names none
◆ VOLATILE → Field Sheet.

Six bases, one set of questions.

We name no hotels — we haven't slept in them and they'd be wrong by spring. We assess areas, on the same three questions each, so you can choose the base and pick the room yourself.

The question this book answers is not which hotel but which neighbourhood, because on a Greek trip the base decides the day far more than the room does. Each area below is read on the same axes: what it's best for, and what you trade to get it.

THE BASES

AREA · BEST FOR · THE TRADE

Athens — Plakacharm over value; busiest in the core • **STRUCTURAL**

first-timers: old-town lanes under the Acropolis, walkable to everything

Athens — Koukaki / Monastirakia few minutes further from the sights • **STRUCTURAL**

a local feel and better value, or nightlife on the doorstep

Santorini — Oia / Imeroviglithe island's top prices; you swim elsewhere • **STRUCTURAL**

the caldera postcard and the sunset

Santorini — Firabusier, less serene than the northern villages • **STRUCTURAL**

central, better value, transport and nightlife

Santorini — Kamari / Perissaaway from the caldera views • **STRUCTURAL**

a beach base with the most room per dollar

Naxos / Paros — the main townsless glamour than the icons, which is the point • **STRUCTURAL**

value, real villages, easy ferry access

THE DECISION TREE

Is this a once-in-a-decade, scenery-first trip? → Caldera base on Santorini — Oia or Imerovigli — for two or three nights, and swim on the east coast.

Is it beach-and-relaxation first? → Naxos or a Perissa/Kamari base; give the caldera two nights, no more.

Is it your first hours in the country? → Plaka. Walkable, central, minutes from the Acropolis and a short Metro from the ferries.

And there is Santorini at the right hour — not Oia at sunset shoulder to shoulder, but Imerovigli twenty minutes earlier, the caldera dropping away blue-black beneath you and the white towns beginning to catch the gold, and the sense, rare in a famous place, that the postcard was underselling it.

Ten days, as operations.

Not an hour-by-hour itinerary — the load-bearing moves, in order, with the reason each is where it is.

DAYS 1–3 · ATHENS

Land mid-morning off the nonstop; Metro Line 3 into Plaka (~40 min). Ease in day one — lanes, a first taverna. Day two is the headliners: Acropolis at opening to beat heat and crowds, the museum, the Agora. Day three slows down or takes one spoke — Sounion or Delphi. Then Piraeus.

DAYS 4–6 • NAXOS

Ferry from Piraeus to the relaxed, authentic heart of the Cyclades. Long sandy beaches, hill villages, the marble Portara at sunset. This is the island that holds you — three nights, no boat in the middle.

DAYS 7–9 • SANTORINI

A short hop south to the finale. Base on the caldera, swim on the east coast, watch the sunset from Imerovigli or an early Oia. Two full days is plenty for the caldera walk, a beach, and the sunset.

DAY 10 • HOME

Fly Santorini → Athens to connect home, rather than sail the long ferry back. The finale-then-flight shape is why Santorini goes last.

FLEXING IT

Want energy over quiet villages? Swap Naxos for Mykonos and the structure is unchanged. Two weeks? Add Paros between Naxos and Santorini, or fold in Crete by a short flight — never by the long boat.

Twenty ways the trip goes wrong, by what it costs you.

A website of articles can tell you what to do. Only a manual can organise the mistakes by their consequence — so you can see which ones truly matter.

COSTS YOU DAYS

Booking four or five islands because the map allows it — each hop eats most of a day.

Combining islands from distant groups on a short trip — long sailings and backtracks through Athens.

Building a tight itinerary on last year's timetable — a dropped sailing takes the chain down.

Putting Santorini in the middle — you pay a long ferry day instead of a short flight home.

Sprinting to Piraeus for a same-day ferry on arrival — a jet-lagged day lost to logistics.

COSTS YOU MONEY

Answering 'dollars' at the card reader — dynamic currency conversion at a bad rate.

Withdrawing from Euronet ATMs — poor rates and high fees, in every tourist area.

Carrying only a card with foreign-transaction fees — a percentage on every purchase.

Relying on Amex alone — less widely accepted than Visa or Mastercard.

Booking the caldera for a week — the priciest beds in Greece, past their point after three days.

COSTS YOU THE EXPERIENCE

Going in July–August by default — hottest, busiest, priciest, when the shoulder is better on every axis.

Watching the sunset only from Oia — the island's worst crowd, when Imerovigli is emptier and as good.

Booking a caldera hotel expecting to swim there — the beaches are on the far coast.

Turning up to dinner at 7pm — you'll have the taverna to yourself, and not in a good way.

Ordering a plate each instead of sharing — you miss the entire point of the table.

COSTS YOU AT THE DESK OR THE BORDER

Driving a bigger island without an International Driving Permit — refused the car, or uninsured in a crash.

A passport under three months' validity past departure, or over ten years old — turned away.

Assuming ETIAS rules are last year's — they are changing; confirm officially in your travel week.

Over-packing — heavy bags on port hikes, island steps, and cobbles are a real burden.

Taking the fast boat in a stiff meltemi — the first sailing to be cancelled when the wind is up.

Go slowly, and end on the icon.

The magic of the Greek islands reveals itself in the unhurried moments — the long lunch that becomes an afternoon, the beach you return to because you loved it.

If this book has one argument, it is that restraint is the entire game. The travellers who come home raving are the ones who gave two or three islands room to breathe, not the ones who collected six. Depth beats breadth: two islands you come to know, a taverna where they remember you on the second night, a beach worth a second visit. You cannot get that while constantly packing.

So take fewer islands than the map tempts you toward. Move between neighbours. Go in the shoulder season if you can. End on Santorini, and fly home rather than sail. And when the boat is an hour out and the coffee is going cold, don't reach for the phone — that hour is not dead time between islands. On this trip, done right, it is the trip.

And there is the first evening in a taverna that has no sign in English, where the food comes in waves you didn't order in any particular order, and the check does not come at all until you ask, and you realise around the second small plate that the unhurriedness is not poor service but the entire point.

• • •

Carry this.

The entire book, compressed to the reflexes you need at a counter, a port, or a card reader. Print the page; fold it in your passport.

GREECE — THE REFLEXES		GREECEFORAMERICANS.COM
At the card reader	Always euros, never dollars	
At the ATM	Bank machine, not Euronet	
Ferry legs	Fast on long hauls; slow, fine on short hops	
In high wind	The fast boat cancels first	
Islands per 10 days	Two or three, not more	
Nights per island	Three minimum	
Santorini	Finale, not middle; fly home	
Swim on Santorini	East coast, not the caldera	
Sunset	Imerovigli or early Oia	
Dinner	After 9pm; order to share; ask for the check	
Driving	IDP from AAA, before you fly	
Passport	3+ months past departure; under 10 years old	

The refusals are the product.

A paid manual earns trust by what it declines to fake. Here is what this book will not do, and why each refusal makes the rest more reliable.

It won't name hotels.

We haven't slept in them. A name we can't stand behind is worse than a criterion you can apply yourself — so we assess neighbourhoods and let you pick the room.

It won't name restaurants.

The good taverna this spring may be tired by autumn, and a printed list of names ages badly. The rule — late, shared, unhurried — outlives any list, so we print the rule.

It won't print current prices.

A price on paper is wrong the moment it's wrong, and quietly. Every figure that moves lives on the dated Field Sheet, where it can be reissued, not buried in a book that looks authoritative.

It won't republish anyone's ratings.

Star scores from booking platforms are both legally off-limits to resell and editorially hollow. We'd rather show you how to decide than launder someone else's crowd-sourced number.

THE FIELD SHEET

The dated annex.

Everything here moves. Verified figures carry a date; everything else names the official place to confirm it in your travel week. There are no blank cells and no guesses.

Survey method: the structural claims in this book were checked against the greeceforamericans.com corpus in July 2026. The figures below are either verified at that press time or, where a value moves too fast to print, replaced with the authoritative source to check. ▲ SURVEYED 07/26.

ENTRY & DOCUMENTS

Schengen visa-free tourist stay	90 days in any 180 · official, stable
Passport validity required	3+ months beyond Schengen departure; is:
EES biometric border	In effect · confirm process at travel.s
ETIAS authorisation & fee	Confirm status and fee at the official I

MONEY

Currency	Euro (€)
EUR–USD rate	Moves daily · check your bank's app befo
At the card reader	Always choose euros, never dollars (avo:
ATMs to use	Greek bank machines (Alpha, Piraeus, Na

FERRIES

Piraeus → Santorini	~5 h fast / ~8 h conventional · confirm
Naxos → Santorini	~1.5 h fast · confirm on an operator or
Booking window	High-speed & Jul–Aug: book ahead; shoul
Schedules	Seasonal, confirmed close to travel – v

GETTING AROUND

ATH → central Athens	Metro Line 3, ~40 min · low single-digi
Driving permit (bigger islands)	International Driving Permit from AAA, I
Connectivity	eSIM, installed before arrival · compar
Domestic flights	Santorini/Crete ↔ Athens · check curren

